ORGANIZATION OF AMERICAN STATES

The Organization of American States (OAS) is the world's oldest regional organization, comprising 35 independent states of the Americas—the North, Central and South America—and the Caribbean, with its headquarters in Washington, DC. Government of Cuba, a member state, has been suspended from participation since 1962. Therefore, only 34 countries participate actively. There are also permanent observers. As of 2008, there are 61 permanent observer countries, including the European Union.

The notion of closer hemispheric union in the Americas was first put forward by Simón Bolívar who, at the 1826 Congress of Panama, proposed a creation of a league of American Republics with a common military, mutual defence pact, and a supranational parliamentary assembly. This idea of regional solidarity and cooperation was again raised in 1889–1890, at the First International Conference of American States. Eighteen nations meeting in Washington DC, resolved to establish the International Union of American Republics, served by a permanent secretariat, called the **Commercial Bureau of the American Republics.** These developments were the precursors to the present OAS and its General Secretariat. Since then a number of other initiatives tried to boost the American unity. Finally, in 1948 at the Ninth International Conference of American States held in Bogotá and led by the US Secretary of State, George Marshall, a pledge was taken by the members to fight Communism in America. This perspective of containing Communism ultimately gave birth to the OAS as it stands today. The Charter of the OAS was signed by 21 American countries on 30 April 1948, which came into effect since December 1951. The American Declaration of the Rights and Duties of Man, the world's first general human rights instrument, was also adopted in this meeting.

Article 1 of the Charter embodies the goal of the member nations in creating the OAS. It upholds its primary goal "to achieve an order of peace and justice, to promote their solidarity, to strengthen their collaboration, and to defend their sovereignty, their territorial integrity, and their independence".